China’s mediation effort at this juncture represented a marked departure from its traditionally low-profile approach to Middle East problems. In late 2013, Beijing launched a major effort to mediate between Iran and the United States in an effort to avert yet another war in the Persian Gulf. China’s mediation effort at this juncture was one component of the more proactive great power diplomacy mandated by Xi Jinping shortly after he took power in November 2012. Between late 2013 and the conclusion of the JCPOA in July 2015, at least 17 high-ranking Chinese representatives, including Xi Jinping, in talks with Iran’s new President Hasan Rouhani, urged Iran to do what was necessary to assuage international concerns over Iran’s nuclear programmes, thereby opening the path to a comprehensive and final solution of the Iran nuclear issue. Simultaneously, China urged the P5+1 to agree to lift all economic sanctions, recognise Iran’s “right” to peaceful use of nuclear energy under the provisions of the Non Proliferation Treaty, and abjure resorting to further sanctions or use or threatened use of military force against Iran. China issued its own proposals regarding a final, comprehensive settlement, the first time it had done this, according to Chinese sources. Beijing also made it clear to Tehran that if the nuclear issue could be set aside and sanctions lifted, China was prepared to play a major role in Iran’s industrialisation and infrastructure development. This was an attractive “carrot” for Tehran. Once the July 2015 deal was signed, multiple top-ranking Iranian representatives expressed gratitude to China for its “important and constructive” role in negotiations that culminated in the July 2015 agreement.

Beijing seems to have used its successful mediatory role in conclusion of the JCPOA as leverage for the launch of its bid for substantially expanded cooperation with Iran. Xi arrived in Tehran only days after the JCPOA came fully into effect. The implicit message: China was a reliable and effective help-mate to Iran on issues of war and peace. Iran could and